

SCIENCE OF READING REVIEW: UNIVERSITY OF THE OZARKS

TRADITIONAL

On-Site Review: October 8-11, 2024

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

This report uses evidence from an on-site review to examine how an educator preparation program prepares candidates to teach reading using scientific reading instruction, as Arkansas requires of every approved program. It is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

The on-site reviews are carried out by Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US), an external review organization. TPI-US teams inspect coursework and course materials, observe instruction and clinical practice, review program data, and hold focus groups with candidates, faculty, mentor teachers, and school partners. Division of Elementary and Secondary Education staff participate in the review.

TPI-US rates the program in the three review areas of the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

- Review Area 1, "Quality of Literacy Coursework," is rated from course materials, syllabi, assignments, and observations of instruction.
- Review Area 2, "Quality of Field-Based Experiences," is rated from placement records, observation and feedback evidence, and focus groups with candidates, mentor teachers, faculty, and school partners.
- Review Area 3, "Quality of Performance Management and Continuous Improvement," is rated from program data systems, quality-control checkpoints, monitoring practice, and partnership evidence.

Every review area receives a rating. Depending on the framework version, the report may also rate each criterion; some earlier reports discuss every criterion without stating a separate rating for it. Performance Levels are defined as follows, in language drawn from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

PERFORMANCE LEVEL	WHAT THE RATING MEANS
4 — EXCEEDS	Coursework and training CONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
3 — MEETS	Coursework and training USUALLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
2 — APPROACHING	Coursework and training INCONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
1 — BELOW	Coursework and training RARELY OR DO NOT address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.

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REVIEW AREA PERFORMANCE LEVELS		
REVIEW AREA 1 LITERACY COURSEWORK	REVIEW AREA 2 FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES	REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT
APPROACHING	APPROACHING	APPROACHING
CRITERIA REVIEWED		
9	11	7
CORRECTIVE ACTION STATUS		
Corrective action determination issued for this review cycle. The Division identified 10 corrective actions for this program, of which 4 are required.		

PROGRAM INFORMATION

INSTITUTION NAME	University of the Ozarks
LOCATION	Clarksville, Arkansas
PROGRAM REVIEWED	Educator preparation program, literacy
PATHWAY	Traditional
REVIEW FRAMEWORK	TPI-US Arkansas SOR Review Framework (2024)
REVIEWING BODY	Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US)
SITE VISIT DATES	October 8-11, 2024

REVIEW AREA 1: QUALITY OF LITERACY COURSEWORK

REVIEW AREA 1 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
APPROACHING 9 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Overview of the science of reading	Approaching
Concepts of print instruction	Approaching
Collaborative communication, oral language instruction	Meets
Phonological and phonemic awareness instruction	Meets
Phonics, orthography, automatic word recognition instruction	Meets
Fluency instruction	Meets
Vocabulary instruction	Meets
Text comprehension instruction	Approaching
Writing instruction	Approaching
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers found that four literacy courses, EDU 3213 Foundations of Reading I, EDU 3243 Foundations of Reading II, EDU 4053 Disciplinary Reading and Writing, and EDU 4063 Literacy Assessment and Intervention, together built a cohesive science of reading foundation using Scarborough's Rope, the Simple View of Reading, the Four-Part Processing Model, and Ehri's phases. Phonological and phonemic awareness, phonics and orthography, fluency, vocabulary, and oral language instruction met expectations, supported by systematic modeling of all 44 phonemes. Concepts of print, text comprehension, and writing instruction approached expectations. Reviewers found limited practice delivering instruction and administering assessments, and few differentiation strategies for multilingual learners.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Comprehensive modeling • Build candidates' instructional capacity • Infuse writing in all literacy course content and coursework • Address diverse learners' needs in all literacy coursework	
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA	
Nine of the ten corrective actions target this review area.	

REVIEW AREA 2: QUALITY OF FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES

REVIEW AREA 2 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
APPROACHING 11 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Selection of clinical placement schools	Approaching
Selection of cooperating teachers (mentor teachers)	Approaching
Opportunities to observe models of effective early literacy practice	Approaching
Field-based placements provide opportunities to use HQIM	Approaching
Responsibilities build to candidate readiness for full responsibility	Approaching
Opportunities to apply learning about multilingual children	Below
Opportunities to apply learning about students who experience difficulty reading	Approaching
Mentor teachers are skillful and can coach candidates	Approaching
Faculty and supervisors guide and evaluate candidates through training	Approaching
Quality of written and oral feedback	Approaching
Student engagement and candidate impact on student learning	Approaching
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers found field-based experiences approaching expectations across most criteria. Of the 18 placement schools in five districts, five were rated B and 12 were rated C in the 2022 Arkansas ratings, with one school showing no rating, and all 18 enrolled 52 to 77 percent of students on free or reduced lunch. Mentor teacher selection relied on informal, discretionary practices, and few current mentors could articulate the state criteria. Candidates encountered high-quality instructional materials and strong literacy modeling by chance rather than through intentional program planning. Preparation for multilingual learners rated below expectations because no structured approach ensured candidates worked with those students.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Ensure skilled and effective mentor teachers • Enhance mentor selection • Revise training and standardize coaching • Revise all field experiences to align with coursework	
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA	
Three of the ten corrective actions target this review area.	

REVIEW AREA 3: QUALITY OF PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT AND CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
APPROACHING 7 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Quality of data the program collects and uses	Approaching
Internal quality control gates (or checkpoints) and intervention plans	Approaching
Quality of monitoring	Approaching
Monitoring coursework quality, teaching quality, and clinical connections	Approaching
Quality improvement planning	Approaching
Partnerships improve candidate experiences with HQIM	Approaching
Evaluation of partnerships for readiness to teach early literacy	Approaching
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers found performance management approaching expectations in every criterion. Data collection was informal and manual, with evaluations completed by hand and transferred into spreadsheets, and the absence of a centralized digital platform left Praxis pass rates, portfolio assessments, student impact data, and course evaluations fragmented. The program operated six quality control phases from orientation through collection of graduate employment data, but literacy data was not yet integrated into those checkpoints. The director alone observed and evaluated internship candidates, which limited content faculty participation. Partnership agreements lacked specific science of reading expectations.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Improve data collection and utilization • Implement literacy-specific checkpoints for timely interventions • Enhance monitoring system and cycles • Implement monitoring system for all program components	
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA	
No corrective action targets this review area.	

CORRECTIVE ACTION

Where a review identifies findings that require follow-up, the Division of Elementary and Secondary Education issues a corrective action determination. The Division selects from a standard set of corrective actions and marks each one required or recommended for the program. The recommendations under each review area above are the reviewers' advice; the actions below are what the Division has directed the program to do.

ACTIONS IDENTIFIED	REQUIRED	RECOMMENDED
10	4	6

The Division identified 10 corrective actions for this program, 4 required and 6 recommended. Required actions must be completed. Recommended actions are directed to the program as supports for the same findings. Some actions address more than one review area, so the per-area counts shown under each review area add to more than the total.

ACTIONS THE PROGRAM IS REQUIRED TO TAKE

CORRECTIVE ACTION	REVIEW AREA ADDRESSED	DESIGNATION	EVIDENCE REQUIRED
LETRS training or equivalent	RA1	RECOMMENDED	LETRS training certificates
RISE training, proficiency pathway	RA1	RECOMMENDED	RISE training certificates
Walk-through tool training	RA2	REQUIRED	Walk-through tool training certificates
Course revisions	RA1	RECOMMENDED	Revised course syllabi and observations
Inclusive practices training	RA1, RA2	RECOMMENDED	Inclusive practices training certificate
Defined partnerships and collaboration with dyslexia specialists at education cooperatives	RA1	RECOMMENDED	Certificate of completion from Southeast, Great Rivers, or Crowley's Ridge cooperative
Lesson plan internalization training (TNTP)	RA1	REQUIRED	Training certificate
Identify the HQIM in all partner districts and incorporate it into revised coursework	RA1	REQUIRED	Matrix of partner district HQIM and its inclusion in coursework
Small group instruction training, K-2 and 3-6	RA1, RA2	RECOMMENDED	Training certificate; participation through DESE and/or cooperatives
Literacy Foundations for English Learners book study (Elsa Cardenas-Hagan)	RA1	REQUIRED	Book study notes as documentation

OVERSIGHT

Each corrective action carries an evidence requirement, shown above. The program supplies the person responsible, the timeline for completion, and how each action will be used in the program when it submits its corrective action plan to the Division. Those execution details are not recorded in the determination and are therefore not published here.

Sources: TPI-US Written Report & Recommendations, University of the Ozarks, October 8-11, 2024, conducted under the TPI-US Arkansas SOR Review Framework (2024). University of the Ozarks Corrective Action Plan, Arkansas DESE. Rating scale language quoted from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework.